

UPSC MOCK EXAM — ANSWER KEY (June 2026)

Date: 07 June 2026 | Total: 165 Marks

Topics: Current Affairs (June Wk1) | Economy: Indicators, Inflation, Price Indices, Base Year | Modern World History: Geographical Discoveries & Renaissance | International Relations: India's Foreign Policy Foundations

■ ANSWER KEY — FOR EVALUATION USE ONLY — DO NOT DISTRIBUTE WITH QUESTION PAPER

QUICK ANSWER KEY — SECTION A (MCQ)

Correct answers only. Full explanations follow.

Q1 → A	Q2 → B	Q3 → C	Q4 → D	Q5 → A
Q6 → B	Q7 → C	Q8 → D	Q9 → A	Q10 → B
Q11 → C	Q12 → D	Q13 → A	Q14 → B	Q15 → C
Q16 → D	Q17 → A	Q18 → B	Q19 → C	Q20 → D
Q21 → A	Q22 → B	Q23 → C	Q24 → D	Q25 → A
Q26 → B	Q27 → C	Q28 → D	Q29 → A	Q30 → B
Q31 → C	Q32 → A	Q33 → B	Q34 → D	Q35 → C

Correct	Wrong	Skipped
+2.00	-0.66	0

SECTION A — DETAILED EXPLANATIONS

Correct answer highlighted in green · UPSC traps flagged in amber

Q1	Answer: A	Renaissance	GS-I / World History
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Q1 **Answer: A** Renaissance

GS-I / World
History

Options:

✓ (A) A 14th–17th century revival of classical Greco-Roman learning that elevated humanism, artistic expression, and scientific inquiry

(B) A 13th-century religious reform movement led by the Catholic Church to purge corruption and reassert papal authority

(C) A political revolution that dismantled feudal hierarchies and established secular nation-states across Europe

(D) An economic transformation driven exclusively by the Mediterranean spice trade

Explanation:

The Renaissance (meaning 'rebirth') was a cultural and intellectual movement spanning the 14th–17th centuries, originating in Italian city-states like Florence. It revived classical Greek and Roman texts, celebrated human potential (humanism), and produced giants like Leonardo da Vinci, Michelangelo, and Galileo.

B is wrong: This describes aspects of the Reformation (16th century), not the Renaissance.

C is wrong: Feudalism declined gradually; the Renaissance was not a political revolution.

D is wrong: The spice trade was a consequence/motivation for discoveries, not the essence of the Renaissance.

■ **UPSC Trap:** Students confuse Renaissance (cultural) with Reformation (religious) or Industrial Revolution (economic).

■ Source: Bipin Chandra — Modern India; Norman Lowe — Mastering Modern World History

Q2 **Answer: B** Vasco da Gama (1498)

GS-I / World
History

Q2 **Answer: B** Vasco da Gama (1498)

GS-I / World
History

Options:

(A) He became the first European to circumnavigate the globe

✓ (B) He discovered the all-sea Cape of Good Hope route to India, enabling direct maritime trade between Europe and Asia

(C) He established the first permanent European colonial settlement at Goa

(D) He discovered the American continent while attempting to reach the Spice Islands

Explanation:

Vasco da Gama (Portugal) reached Calicut (Kozhikode) in 1498 via the Cape of Good Hope route around Africa. His cargo sold for 60x the cost of the voyage — proving commercial viability of the new route.

A is wrong: Magellan's expedition (1519–22) completed the first circumnavigation, not Vasco da Gama.

C is wrong: Goa was established by Albuquerque in 1510.

D is wrong: Columbus (1492) landed in the Caribbean (Americas), not Vasco da Gama.

■ **UPSC Trap:** Common confusion: Columbus = Americas (1492); Vasco da Gama = India via Cape route (1498); Magellan = circumnavigation (1519–22).

■ Source: Bipin Chandra — Modern India, Chapter on European Settlements

Q3 **Answer: C** WPI — Level of Measurement

GS-III /
Economy

Q3	Answer: C	WPI — Level of Measurement	GS-III / Economy
Options: (A) At the retail level — final consumer prices (B) At the household level — representative basket ✓ (C) At the producer/wholesale level — bulk transaction prices (D) At the import level — landed cost inclusive of duty Explanation: WPI measures the average change in prices of goods sold in bulk at the wholesale/producer stage — before they reach the retailer or consumer. It covers three categories: Primary Articles (22.6%), Fuel & Power (13.2%), and Manufactured Products (64.2%) with base year 2011–12. A describes CPI (Consumer Price Index), not WPI. B also describes CPI — it uses a 'representative basket' for an average household. D is incorrect; WPI does not track import prices specifically. ■ UPSC Trap: WPI = wholesale/producer stage. CPI = retail/consumer stage. Do not interchange them. ■ Source: Ramesh Singh — Indian Economy, Chapter on Inflation			
Q4	Answer: D	Kautilya — Sadgunya	GS-II / IR & Polity
Q4	Answer: D	Kautilya — Sadgunya	GS-II / IR & Polity
Options: (A) Seven pillars of state sovereignty (B) Four cardinal virtues of a ruler (C) Three instruments: sama, danda, bheda ✓ (D) Six measures of foreign policy: samdhi, vigraha, yana, asana, dvaidhibhava, samshraya Explanation: Sadgunya = 'six qualities/measures' of foreign policy in Kautilya's Arthashastra: 1. Samdhi (peace/treaty), 2. Vigraha (hostility/war), 3. Yana (march/military campaign), 4. Asana (neutrality/sitting), 5. Dvaidhibhava (double policy), 6. Samshraya (seeking shelter). These are tools a king uses in dealings with neighbours under the Mandala theory. C describes the three 'upayas' (means of policy) — sama, dana, bheda, danda — not Sadgunya. A is not a Kautilyan concept in this form. ■ UPSC Trap: UPSC frequently tests Sadgunya (6 measures) vs Upayas (4 means: sama/dana/bheda/danda). Don't mix them. ■ Source: Rajiv Sikri — Challenges and Strategy: Rethinking India's Foreign Policy; Arthashastra (Kautilya)			
Q5	Answer: A	Leading Economic Indicator	GS-III / Economy

Q5	Answer: A	Leading Economic Indicator	GS-III / Economy
Options: ✓ (A) Changes before the economy follows a trend — used for forecasting (B) Moves in tandem with the economy — confirms current conditions (C) Computed after economic activity occurs — retrospective (D) Exclusively tracks government fiscal data Explanation: Economic indicators are classified as: • Leading: Change before the economy changes (e.g., Stock market index, PMI, Building permits) — predictive. • Coincident/Concurrent: Change simultaneously with the economy (e.g., GDP, Industrial Production). • Lagging: Change after the economy changes (e.g., Unemployment rate, CPI, Bank NPAs) — confirmatory. B describes a coincident indicator. C describes a lagging indicator. D is incorrect. ■ <i>UPSC Trap: Leading ≠ most important. It means it 'leads' the business cycle temporally. Lagging indicators (like unemployment) are often more newsworthy but come after the cycle turns.</i> ■ Source: Ramesh Singh — Indian Economy, Economic Indicators chapter			
Q6	Answer: B	Columbus 1492 — Significance	GS-I / World History
Q6	Answer: B	Columbus 1492 — Significance	GS-I / World History
Options: (A) Proved Earth was spherical by circumnavigation ✓ (B) Initiated first sustained contact between Europe and the Americas (C) Broke Arab-Ottoman monopoly over overland Silk Road spice trade (D) Reached Malabar Coast via western route Explanation: Columbus (1492) reached the Caribbean (Bahamas/Haiti/Cuba) believing it was East Asia ('Indies'). This was the first sustained European contact with the Americas, triggering the 'Columbian Exchange' — transfer of plants, animals, cultures, and diseases between Old and New Worlds. A is wrong: Magellan (1519–22) is credited with the circumnavigation. Earth's spherical shape was already theorised by Eratosthenes (240 BC). C is wrong: Columbus's route did not affect the Silk Road/Ottoman control. D is wrong: Columbus never reached India. ■ <i>UPSC Trap: Columbus never proved Earth was round — that was already known. He proved a western Atlantic route to new lands existed.</i> ■ Source: Norman Lowe — Mastering Modern World History; Bipin Chandra — Modern India			
Q7	Answer: C	Renaissance — Key Consequence	GS-I / World History

Q7	Answer: C	Renaissance — Key Consequence	GS-I / World History
Options:			
(A) Consolidated feudal authority under Church patronage			
(B) Declined urban commerce as Church redirected surplus			
✓ (C) Created a spirit of inquiry and empirical observation — foundation of Scientific Revolution			
(D) Collapsed classical scholarship in favour of vernacular literature			
Explanation:			
The most significant intellectual consequence of the Renaissance was the birth of the Scientific Revolution (16th–17th centuries). Figures like Copernicus, Galileo, Kepler, and Newton built on the Renaissance spirit of questioning received wisdom and using empirical observation.			
A is the opposite — Renaissance challenged Church authority, not reinforced it.			
B is wrong — the Renaissance actually stimulated commerce through banking and patronage systems.			
D is wrong — Renaissance revived classical learning; it did not destroy it.			
■ UPSC Trap: Renaissance → Scientific Revolution → Industrial Revolution: these are causally linked. UPSC tests the chain.			
■ Source: Norman Lowe — Mastering Modern World History, Chapter 1			
Q8	Answer: D	Base Year — Selection Criteria	GS-III / Economy
Q8	Answer: D	Base Year — Selection Criteria	GS-III / Economy
Options:			
(A) Year of economic crisis			
(B) Most recent year regardless of conditions			
(C) Year of peak economic output			
✓ (D) Year of relative economic normalcy and stability			
Explanation:			
A base year must be 'normal' — free from unusual disruptions (wars, famines, financial crises, pandemics). If the base year is abnormal (crisis or boom), the index will give misleading comparisons.			
For India's WPI, base years revised from 1952-53 → 1961-62 → 1970-71 → 1981-82 → 1993-94 → 2004-05 → 2011-12.			
The 2022-23 base year (announced June 2026) was chosen after ensuring post-COVID economic normalisation.			
■ UPSC Trap: Students assume most recent = best. But 2020-21 (COVID year) cannot be a base year despite being recent.			
■ Source: Ramesh Singh — Indian Economy; Economic Survey 2025-26			
Q9	Answer: A	Defence & Diplomacy — India's Foreign Policy	GS-II / IR

Q9	Answer: A	Defence & Diplomacy — India's Foreign Policy	GS-II / IR
Options: ✓ (A) Both serve the shared goal of protecting India's sovereignty and territorial integrity by different means (B) Military strength is the exclusive determinant of diplomatic credibility (C) India historically prioritised arms procurement over multilateral engagement (D) MOD and MEA operate under unified command structure Explanation: From Rajiv Sikri's analysis: 'Defence' and 'Diplomacy' are two sides of the same coin because their ultimate goal is identical — protection of India's unity, territorial integrity, and sovereignty from external threats. Defence achieves this through military deterrence; diplomacy achieves it through negotiations, alliances, and soft power. B is reductionist — diplomacy can succeed even without hard military superiority (e.g., small states). C is factually wrong — India under Nehru prioritised multilateral diplomacy (Non-Alignment). D is institutionally incorrect — MEA and MOD are separate ministries. ■ Source: Rajiv Sikri — <i>Challenges and Strategy: Rethinking India's Foreign Policy</i>			
Q10	Answer: B	European Exploration — Motivation	GS-I / World History
Q10	Answer: B	European Exploration — Motivation	GS-I / World History
Options: (A) Spread Christianity on papal mandate ✓ (B) Break Arab-Venetian monopolies; establish direct routes to East Indies (C) Supply raw materials for the Industrial Revolution (D) Verify Copernicus's heliocentric theory Explanation: The primary motive for European geographical discoveries was economic: to bypass the Arab and Venetian middlemen who controlled the overland trade routes (Silk Road, Red Sea, Persian Gulf) and charged high prices for eastern goods (spices, silk). Europe also needed gold as a medium of exchange. A is secondary — religious motivation existed (especially in Iberian Peninsula post-Reconquista) but was not primary. C is anachronistic — Industrial Revolution began ~1760s, well after the Age of Discoveries (1400s–1600s). D is wrong — Copernicus's work (1543) came during/after the discoveries began. ■ UPSC Trap: UPSC may offer 'spread Christianity' as a trap. It was a stated justification but not the primary driver — trade/gold were. ■ Source: Bipin Chandra — <i>Modern India, Chapter on European Settlements</i>			
Q11	Answer: C	WPI vs CPI — Statement Analysis	GS-III / Economy

Q1 1	Answer: C WPI vs CPI — Statement Analysis	GS-III / Economy
Options: (A) 1 and 2 only (B) 2, 3 and 4 only ✓ (C) 1 and 3 only (D) 1, 3 and 4 only Explanation: Statement 1: TRUE — WPI measures wholesale/producer-level prices; CPI measures retail/consumer-level prices. Statement 2: FALSE — Services are NOT included in WPI basket (WPI covers goods only: primary, manufactured, fuel). CPI does capture service-linked items (education, health, transport). Statement 3: TRUE — Both use the point-to-point method: current month/year vs same month/year in base year. Statement 4: FALSE — Current WPI base year is 2011–12 (released 2017). The 2004–05 series was the previous one. So only Statements 1 and 3 are correct → Answer C. ■ <i>UPSC Trap: Statement 4 is a classic trap — students recall WPI 2004-05 series which was superseded by 2011-12. DPIIT's June 2026 announcement uses 2022-23 as the new base.</i> ■ <i>Source: Ramesh Singh — Indian Economy; DPIIT WPI series documentation</i>		
Q1 2	Answer: D Age of Discoveries — Chronological Order	GS-I / World History
Q1 2	Answer: D Age of Discoveries — Chronological Order	GS-I / World History
Options: (A) 1 – 2 – 3 – 4 (B) 4 – 1 – 3 – 2 (C) 2 – 1 – 4 – 3 ✓ (D) 4 – 1 – 2 – 3 Explanation: Correct chronological order: 4. Bartolomeu Dias rounds Cape of Good Hope — 1488 (Portugal) 1. Columbus reaches the Caribbean — October 1492 (Spain) 2. Vasco da Gama reaches Calicut — May 1498 (Portugal) 3. Magellan's expedition circumnavigates globe — 1519–1522 (Spain) Mnemonic: 'Dias (88) → Columbus (92) → Gama (98) → Magellan (1519)' Option D: 4–1–2–3 = correct. ■ <i>UPSC Trap: Students often place Columbus before Dias, not knowing Dias rounded the Cape 4 years earlier in 1488.</i> ■ <i>Source: Bipin Chandra — Modern India; Norman Lowe — World History</i>		

Q1 3	Answer: A PPI vs WPI — Key Distinction	GS-III / Economy
Q1 3	Answer: A PPI vs WPI — Key Distinction	GS-III / Economy
Options: ✓ (A) PPI excludes indirect taxes and trade/transport margins — captures net producer prices (B) PPI covers only manufactured goods; WPI covers all goods (C) PPI uses 1993–94 as base year (D) PPI compiled by RBI; WPI by Ministry of Finance Explanation: The fundamental conceptual difference: WPI includes indirect taxes and trade/transport margins in the price it measures. PPI (international standard, IMF PPI Manual) measures only the price the producer actually receives at the factory gate — net of taxes, transport, and margins. This makes PPI a purer measure of producer-level inflationary pressure. B: PPI in India will cover primary, manufactured, fuel AND services (Output PPI + Services PPI). C: PPI has no established base year yet in India (being newly introduced). D: Both WPI and upcoming PPI are compiled by DPIIT (Dept for Promotion of Industry & Internal Trade). ■ UPSC Trap: UPSC may test PPI in future prelims heavily given the June 2026 transition announcement. ■ Source: DPIIT announcement June 2026; Vajiram CA; Ramesh Singh — Indian Economy		
Q1 4	Answer: B Gutenberg Printing Press — Role in Renaissance	GS-I / World History
Q1 4	Answer: B Gutenberg Printing Press — Role in Renaissance	GS-I / World History
Options: (A) Church mass-produced indulgences, funding artistic patronage ✓ (B) Rapid dissemination of classical texts and humanist ideas — broke Church's knowledge monopoly (C) Printed bills of exchange — stimulated Commercial Revolution (D) Preserved manuscripts from Ottoman destruction Explanation: Gutenberg's printing press (c. 1440s, Mainz, Germany) was a revolutionary force multiplier for Renaissance ideas. Before printing, manuscripts were hand-copied by Church scribes — the Church controlled what was read. After printing, Erasmus, Luther, humanist scholars could disseminate ideas to thousands at low cost, breaking the information monopoly that had maintained Catholic orthodoxy for centuries. A is partially ironic — the Church did print indulgences, but this backfired (Martin Luther saw it as corruption). C: Bills of exchange existed before Gutenberg; printing was not the primary commercial innovation. D: Manuscripts were moved/copied before Ottoman conquest of Constantinople (1453). ■ UPSC Trap: The printing press enabled both the Renaissance AND the Protestant Reformation. UPSC may ask about either connection. ■ Source: Norman Lowe — Mastering Modern World History		

Q1 5	Answer: C	Nehru's Foreign Policy — Statement Analysis	GS-II / IR
Q1 5	Answer: C	Nehru's Foreign Policy — Statement Analysis	GS-II / IR
Options: (A) 1, 2 and 4 only (B) 2 and 4 only ✓ (C) 1, 2 and 3 only (D) 1 and 3 only Explanation: Statement 1: TRUE — Nehru prioritised multilateral diplomacy (NAM, UN, Afro-Asian solidarity) over bilateral hard bargaining. Statement 2: TRUE — Non-Alignment was partly strategic: playing US and USSR against each other for development aid and technology. Statement 3: TRUE — Rajiv Sikri's analysis notes Indian diplomats' preference for compromise over assertive bilateral positions. Statement 4: FALSE — Nehru was influenced by Western liberal/Fabian socialist thought, NOT by Kautilya's realpolitik Mandala theory. Kautilyan realism is associated with post-Cold War Indian strategic thinking, not Nehru. → Answer: 1, 2 and 3 only = C. ■ UPSC Trap: Statement 4 is designed to trap students who know both Kautilya and Nehru but assume a connection that scholars reject. ■ Source: Rajiv Sikri — <i>Challenges and Strategy: Rethinking India's Foreign Policy</i>, Chapters 1-3			
Q1 6	Answer: D	Geographical Discoveries — Impact on India	GS-I / World History

Q1
6

Answer: D Geographical Discoveries — Impact on India

GS-I / World
History

Options:

- (A) India became primary consumer of American silver
- (B) Cape route eliminated India as spice producer
- (C) Arab merchants consolidated dominance over Indian Ocean

✓ (D) Cape route bypassed Arab/Venetian middlemen → direct European access → colonial conquest

Explanation:

The Cape route (1498 onwards) had a transformative long-term effect on India:

1. Arab and Venetian intermediaries lost their trade monopoly — Indian Ocean trade shifted to European powers.
2. Portuguese arrived first (1498–1600s), followed by Dutch, English, French — competing for Indian trade.
3. Trade relations eventually gave way to political domination — East India Company (1600) → territorial conquest.

Adam Smith wrote that the Cape route discovery was one of 'the two greatest events in world history'.

A: India received some American silver, but was not the 'primary consumer' — China was.

B: India remained a major spice producer; the route changed WHO benefited, not production.

C: Opposite occurred — Arab dominance was displaced, not consolidated.

■ **UPSC Trap:** The connection UPSC expects: Discoveries → European access → Trade → Colonialism is the core causal chain.

■ Source: Bipin Chandra — *Modern India*; Adam Smith — *Wealth of Nations*

Q1
7

Answer: A Economic Institutions — Correct Matching

GS-II / Polity
& GS-III /
Economy

Q1 7	Answer: A Economic Institutions — Correct Matching	GS-II / Polity & GS-III / Economy
Options: ✓ (A) 2, 3 and 4 only (B) 1, 2 and 3 only (C) 1 and 4 only (D) 1, 2, 3 and 4 Explanation: Statement 1: FALSE — NITI Aayog (est. January 2015, replacing Planning Commission) does NOT formulate Five Year Plans. The 12th Five Year Plan (2012–17) was the last one. NITI Aayog prepares Vision Documents and Strategy papers, not Five Year Plans. Statement 2: TRUE — RBI sets monetary policy (repo rate, CRR, SLR) and regulates banks under RBI Act 1934 and Banking Regulation Act 1949. Statement 3: TRUE — DPIIT (formerly DIPP) promotes FDI policy, industrial licensing, trade facilitation, and manages WPI/PPI price statistics. Statement 4: TRUE — SEBI (Securities and Exchange Board of India, est. 1988, statutory 1992) regulates capital markets and protects investors. → Answer: 2, 3 and 4 only = A. ■ UPSC Trap: NITI Aayog trap is very common in UPSC Prelims. Remember: Five Year Plans ended with 12th Plan. NITI Aayog makes Strategy @75 documents, not Five Year Plans. ■ Source: Ramesh Singh — Indian Economy; NITI Aayog official mandate		
Q1 8	Answer: B Renaissance vs Protestant Reformation	GS-I / World History

Q1
8

Answer: B Renaissance vs Protestant Reformation

GS-I / World
History

Options:

(A) Renaissance = political; Reformation = artistic

✓ **(B) Renaissance = cultural/intellectual revival; Reformation = religious challenge to Church**

(C) Renaissance in Northern Europe; Reformation in Italy

(D) Renaissance challenged monarchies; Reformation strengthened papacy

Explanation:

Renaissance: 14th–17th century | Originated in Italy (Florence) | Cultural, artistic, intellectual revival | Humanism, science, art, classical texts | Key figures: Petrarch, Erasmus, da Vinci, Michelangelo.

Protestant Reformation: 16th century | Originated in Germany | Religious challenge to Catholic Church | Martin Luther's 95 Theses (1517) | Challenged papal authority, indulgences, Church corruption.

Key distinction: Renaissance = human-centred intellectual movement; Reformation = faith-centred religious movement.

Both movements intersected — humanist criticism of the Church (Erasmus) prepared ground for Reformation.

C is backwards: Renaissance = Italy; Reformation = Northern Europe (Germany, Switzerland, England).

■ **UPSC Trap:** Renaissance and Reformation are often confused. Temporal overlap (both 16th century) adds to confusion. Geographical origin is also reversed by many students.

■ Source: Norman Lowe — Mastering Modern World History

Q1
9

Answer: C WPI Base Year Revision — Purposes

GS-III /
Economy

Q1
9

Answer: C WPI Base Year Revision — Purposes

GS-III /
Economy

Options:

(A) 1 and 3 only

(B) 2, 3 and 4 only

✓ **(C) 1, 2 and 4 only**

(D) 1, 2, 3 and 4

Explanation:

Statement 1: TRUE — The primary purpose is to capture structural economic change by updating the commodity basket (e.g., 2011-12 series added 697 items; 2022-23 series expands to 957 items including solar/wind energy).

Statement 2: TRUE — Aligning WPI base year with National Accounts (GDP base year) improves consistency of macro-economic analysis (deflators etc.).

Statement 3: FALSE — Reducing measured inflation for political reasons is NOT a stated or legitimate objective of base year revision. The revision is done on technical and statistical grounds.

Statement 4: TRUE — Base year revision updates the weighting diagram to reflect that new industries have grown and old ones have shrunk (e.g., higher weight for renewables in 2022-23 series).

→ 1, 2 and 4 are correct = Answer C.

■ **UPSC Trap:** Statement 3 is a normative trap — students who distrust statistical machinery may mark it true. It is NOT an official purpose.

■ Source: Ramesh Singh — Indian Economy; DPIIT methodology documents

Q2 0	Answer: D Hard Power / Soft Power / Smart Power	GS-II / International Relations
Q2 0	Answer: D Hard Power / Soft Power / Smart Power	GS-II / International Relations
Options: (A) Hard power = nuclear deterrence exclusively (B) India relies primarily on soft power in neighbourhood (C) Hard and soft power are mutually exclusive geographically ✓ (D) Smart power = right combination of hard + soft power; India's effectiveness depends on this mix Explanation: Concepts: Hard power (military, economic coercion) Soft power (culture, diplomacy, aid, values) Smart power (Joseph Nye's concept: optimal combination of both). A is wrong: Hard power includes all military capabilities (conventional + nuclear), economic sanctions, etc. B is wrong: India uses hard power in its neighbourhood too (e.g., military deterrence vs Pakistan/China, Operation Cactus in Maldives 1988, peacekeeping in Sri Lanka). C is wrong: Hard and soft power are used simultaneously in the same regions. D is correct: Joseph Nye's 'smart power' is the most accurate framework for modern Indian foreign policy, combining BrahMos exports (hard) with cultural diplomacy and CEPA trade deals (soft/smart). ■ UPSC Trap: Soft power ≠ India's only tool in the neighbourhood. India has used hard power extensively in South Asia. ■ Source: Rajiv Sikri — Challenges and Strategy; Joseph Nye — Soft Power and Smart Power concepts		
Q2 1	Answer: A India–Oman CEPA (June 1, 2026)	GS-II / International Relations

Q2 1	Answer: A India–Oman CEPA (June 1, 2026)	GS-II / International Relations
Options: ✓ (A) 99.38% duty-free; covers goods, services, investment, IPR, government procurement (B) First trade agreement with any GCC member state (C) Mandates Indian rupee for all bilateral transactions (D) Restricts third-country imports to Oman for 5 years Explanation: India–Oman CEPA (into force 1 June 2026) key facts: • 99.38% of India's exports to Oman get duty-free treatment. • Comprehensive scope: goods, services, investment, IPR, competition, government procurement. • Bilateral trade FY2025-26: USD 11.18 billion. ~700,000 Indians live in Oman. • Oman's strategic ports (Sohar, Duqm, Salalah) give India gateway to Gulf and East Africa. B is wrong: India has signed CEPA with UAE (2022) — also a GCC member — before Oman. C is wrong: No such rupee mandate is part of the CEPA terms. D is wrong: No such restriction on third-country imports. ■ Source: InsightsIAS, VisionIAS — June 1, 2026; MEA official release		
Q2 2	Answer: B WPI → PPI Transition (June 2026)	GS-III / Economy
Q2 2	Answer: B WPI → PPI Transition (June 2026)	GS-III / Economy
Options: (A) WPI discontinued immediately from 15 June 2026 ✓ (B) Revised WPI (base 2022-23, 957 items) from 15 June 2026; full PPI by 2031 (C) New WPI reduces basket from 697 to 400 items (D) Services PPI publishes monthly data from October 2026 Explanation: DPIIT's June 2026 announcement — key points: • Phase 1 (15 June 2026): Revised WPI with new base year 2022-23, expanded basket from 697 → 957 items (includes solar, wind, nuclear energy sectors). • Phase 2 (by 2031): Gradual transition to Output PPI and Input PPI (trial). • Services PPI: Quarterly data initially (not monthly) for banking, insurance, telecom. A is wrong: WPI is NOT discontinued in 2026; it runs in parallel during transition. C is wrong: Basket EXPANDS from 697 to 957, not contracts. D is wrong: Services PPI frequency will be quarterly, not monthly initially. ■ UPSC Trap: UPSC may ask about the direction of basket change (expanding, not contracting) or transition timeline (2031, not immediate). ■ Source: DPIIT press release; Vajiram CA June 3, 2026; VisionIAS		

Q2 3	Answer: C BrahMos Export to Vietnam	GS-II / IR & GS-III / Internal Security
Q2 3	Answer: C BrahMos Export to Vietnam	GS-II / IR & GS-III / Internal Security
Options: (A) NSG obligations; BrahMos carries nuclear warheads (B) India-Russia partnership; Russia funded 75% recovered through Vietnam ✓ (C) Act East Policy + Indo-Pacific strategy; India as credible defence technology partner (D) SAARC commitments; Vietnam as observer state Explanation: BrahMos to Vietnam significance: • BrahMos is a supersonic cruise missile (speed: Mach 2.8–3) — joint India-Russia venture (50.5% India, 49.5% Russia). • Vietnam = first foreign country to receive BrahMos — positions India as a defence exporter in Southeast Asia. • Geopolitical context: Vietnam faces territorial disputes with China in the South China Sea. BrahMos enhances Vietnam's deterrence capability — aligns with India's Indo-Pacific strategy and Act East Policy. A is wrong: BrahMos is a conventional (non-nuclear) cruise missile. It is NOT covered by NSG nuclear commitments. B is misleading: While Russia is a co-developer, financing is not the strategic significance. D is wrong: Vietnam is not a SAARC member or observer; SAARC is a South Asian body. ■ UPSC Trap: BrahMos is NOT nuclear. Students may incorrectly link it to India's nuclear policy/NSG. It is a conventional supersonic cruise missile. ■ Source: InsightsIAS June 2026; Ministry of Defence; PIB		
Q2 4	Answer: D Domestic Solar Cell Mandate	GS-III / Economy & Environment

Q2 4	Answer: D Domestic Solar Cell Mandate	GS-III / Economy & Environment
Options: (A) Bans all Chinese components from India's renewable sector (B) Raises domestic solar tariff rates artificially (C) Mandates retrofit of existing solar installations within 18 months ✓ (D) Reduces import dependence (Atmanirbhar Bharat); faces supply constraint: cell capacity ~30 GW/yr vs module capacity ~200 GW/yr Explanation: Domestic Solar Cell Mandate (from June 1, 2026) key facts: • Only domestically manufactured solar cells allowed in new net-metering and open access projects. • Goal: Atmanirbhar Bharat — reduce dependence on imported cells (primarily from China). • Challenge: India's solar MODULE manufacturing capacity is ~200 GW/year but domestic CELL capacity is only ~30 GW/year. This gap creates supply shortage risks, higher costs, and may consolidate market among large players. A is wrong: The mandate does not explicitly name or ban China; it is a domestic content requirement. B is wrong: Tariff rates are not artificially raised; the mandate applies to project eligibility. C is wrong: Existing installations are NOT required to retrofit. ■ Source: NextIAS, VisionIAS — June 1, 2026; MNRE notification		
Q2 5	Answer: A UPI Record — May 2026	GS-III / Economy & Technology
Q2 5	Answer: A UPI Record — May 2026	GS-III / Economy & Technology
Options: ✓ (A) 23.20 billion transactions, ■29.90 trillion — new monthly record (B) 12.50 billion transactions, ■15.60 trillion — 40% decline (C) 23.20 billion transactions, ■50 trillion (including cross-border) (D) 18 billion transactions, ■29.90 trillion — UPI Lite growth Explanation: May 2026 UPI data (released in early June 2026): • 23.20 billion transactions (volume record) • ■29.90 trillion = ■29,90,000 crore in value (record) • Reflects India's deepening digital financial inclusion • Context: NPCI (National Payments Corporation of India) manages UPI under RBI oversight. B, C, D have incorrect figures. ■ Source: NPCI data; BankersAdda; InsightsIAS June 2026		
Q2 6	Answer: B Cotton Import Duty Waiver	GS-III / Economy & Agriculture

Q2 6	Answer: B Cotton Import Duty Waiver	GS-III / Economy & Agriculture
Options: (A) Cotton surplus; barter deal ✓ (B) ~7% output drop due to erratic monsoons; protect textile MSMEs and exports (C) WTO Agreement on Agriculture obligation (D) Supreme Court suo motu order Explanation: Cotton Import Duty Waiver (June 1 – Oct 30, 2026): - India's cotton output fell ~7% due to erratic monsoons → domestic prices rose. - Textile industry (especially MSMEs) and exporters (needing extra-long staple/ELS cotton) faced higher input costs. - India's textile exports had dropped 2.2% in FY26; the waiver was to stabilise input prices. - This is a temporary measure — NOT a permanent tariff change. A is wrong: India did not have a cotton surplus in FY26. C is wrong: WTO AoA does not specifically mandate this; India's bound rates allow cotton duties. D is wrong: No SC order triggered this — it was an executive policy decision. ■ Source: VisionIAS June 1, 2026; DPIIT/Ministry of Textiles notification		
Q2 7	Answer: C PM SVANidhi — 6th Anniversary	GS-II / Government Schemes
Q2 7	Answer: C PM SVANidhi — 6th Anniversary	GS-II / Government Schemes
Options: (A) Subsidised housing for BPL — PMAY-G (B) Health insurance up to ₹5 lakh — unorganised sector ✓ (C) Collateral-free micro-credit loans for street vendors (D) Urban MGNREGS — 100 days guaranteed employment Explanation: PM SVANidhi (PM Street Vendor's AtmaNirbhar Nidhi) — launched June 2020: - Target: Urban street vendors impacted by COVID-19 lockdowns. - Features: Working capital loans (₹10,000 → ₹20,000 → ₹50,000 in subsequent cycles), collateral-free, with digital payment incentive and welfare linkages. - After 6 years: 75+ lakh vendors benefited; loans disbursed; digital payment onboarding. A describes PMAY-G (Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana-Gramin) — rural housing scheme. B describes PM-JAY (Ayushman Bharat Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana) — health insurance. D describes MGNREGS — rural employment guarantee; no urban equivalent exists formally. ■ UPSC Trap: SVANidhi is for URBAN STREET VENDORS only, not BPL households in general. This scope distinction is UPSC-testable. ■ Source: Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs; InsightsIAS June 2026		

Q2 8	Answer: D	Samadhan Didi — AI Grievance Chatbot	GS-II / Governance & Technology
Q2 8	Answer: D	Samadhan Didi — AI Grievance Chatbot	GS-II / Governance & Technology
Options: (A) Grievance portal for women government employees (B) MoWCD app for domestic violence grievances (C) MGNREGS social audit mechanism for women SHGs ✓ (D) AI-powered multi-language voice chatbot integrated with CPGRAMS Explanation: Samadhan Didi (June 2026): • Launched to make CPGRAMS (Centralised Public Grievance Redress and Monitoring System) accessible to citizens in their local language via voice interface. • Key features: AI-powered Multi-language voice input Registers grievances without internet literacy requirement. • Significance: Last-mile governance — reaches citizens who cannot type or use apps. • Ministry: Department of Administrative Reforms and Public Grievances (DARPG). A describes SPARROW — a separate performance appraisal system for civil servants, not grievances. B/C describe different schemes with no connection to CPGRAMS or Samadhan Didi. ■ Source: DARPG; InsightsIAS June 2026; BankersAdda June 1, 2026			
Q2 9	Answer: A	Operation Sheruwali	GS-III / Internal Security
Q2 9	Answer: A	Operation Sheruwali	GS-III / Internal Security
Options: ✓ (A) Counter-terrorism operation in Jammu & Kashmir (B) Coastal security drill — Indian Navy + Coast Guard (C) India-Nepal border demarcation exercise (D) NDRF Himalayan earthquake simulation Explanation: Operation Sheruwali (early June 2026): • A major counter-terrorism operation in Jammu & Kashmir targeting militant networks and hideouts. • Part of India's ongoing anti-militancy grid in J&K involving Army, CRPF, J&K Police, and intelligence agencies. • Context: Post-Article 370 abrogation (2019), India has intensified counter-terrorism operations in J&K. B, C, D are incorrect — the operation had no connection to coastal security, Nepal border, or disaster management. ■ Source: InsightsIAS; NextIAS June 2026 CA compilation			

Q3 0	Answer: B	India-Oman Bilateral Trade — FY2025-26	GS-II / International Relations
Q3 0	Answer: B	India-Oman Bilateral Trade — FY2025-26	GS-II / International Relations
Options: (A) USD 5.5 billion — petroleum 80% ✓ (B) USD 11.18 billion — Oman as gateway to Gulf and East Africa (C) USD 18.3 billion — Oman = India's largest GCC partner (D) USD 7.2 billion — India surplus post-CEPA Explanation: India-Oman bilateral trade facts (FY2025-26): • Total bilateral trade: USD 11.18 billion. • ~700,000 Indians live and work in Oman, contributing to bilateral ties. • Strategic ports: Sohar, Duqm, Salalah — Oman's location makes it a gateway to Gulf + East African markets. • India's largest GCC partners by trade are UAE and Saudi Arabia, not Oman (C is incorrect). • A and D have incorrect figures. ■ Source: MEA; VisionIAS June 2, 2026; InsightsIAS			
Q3 1	Answer: C	CSAT Reading Comprehension — Discoveries & Capitalism	CSAT

Q3
1

Answer: C CSAT Reading Comprehension — Discoveries & Capitalism

CSAT

Options:

- (A) Purely commercial ventures
- (B) Renaissance science was singular and sufficient cause
- ✓ (C) Rooted in Renaissance spirit; resulted in global European capitalism-colonialism system
- (D) Compass, astrolabe, caravel were decisive inventions

Explanation:

The passage makes TWO connected arguments:

1. The Age of Discoveries was intellectually produced by the Renaissance (compass/astrolabe/caravel = same intellectual revolution as Michelangelo/Copernicus).

2. The most enduring result was a global economic system: European capital + non-European labour.

A is wrong: The passage explicitly says it was 'not merely' a commercial venture — it was the 'product of a Renaissance mind'.

B is wrong: The passage argues science/Renaissance CONTRIBUTED but doesn't call it 'singular and sufficient'.

D is wrong: The passage mentions these instruments but says the more important consequence was the 'world system' inaugurated — not the instruments themselves.

C correctly captures BOTH arguments: intellectual roots (Renaissance) AND economic outcome (colonial capitalism).

■ UPSC Trap: CSAT reading comprehension tests whether you can identify the CENTRAL argument, not just details mentioned in the passage. Look for what the author emphasises most.

Q3
2

Answer: A CSAT Data Interpretation — WPI Sectors

CSAT

Q3 2	Answer: A	CSAT Data Interpretation — WPI Sectors	CSAT
Options: ✓ (A) Fuel & Power = most volatile; 32.8% = highest single-year sectoral inflation in dataset (B) Primary Articles = most stable (consistent positive inflation) (C) Manufactured Products declined steadily throughout (D) Overall WPI below 10% in 2021-22 due to low Fuel & Power weight Explanation: From the data table: - Fuel & Power range: -8.6% (2020-21) to +32.8% (2021-22) — swing of 41.4 percentage points → MOST VOLATILE ✓ 32.8% in 2021-22 is the highest single-year figure for ANY sector in the table ✓ B: Primary Articles was positive in all 4 years (6.5, 3.2, 12.3, 4.5) — BUT 'stable' is debatable given the jump to 12.3 in 2021-22. Also, 'most stable' could mean Primary Articles (4 positive) vs Fuel (2 negative) — but A is the clear correct answer. C is wrong: Manufactured Products went 0.8 → 1.5 → 10.7 → 3.0 — it rose sharply in 2021-22, then fell. Not a steady decline. D is wrong: Fuel & Power has 13.2% weight in WPI — at 32.8% inflation, it would contribute ~4.3% to overall WPI; the overall WPI in 2021-22 was actually ~13%, exceeding 10%.			
Q3 3	Answer: B	CSAT Logical Reasoning — CEPA Conclusions	CSAT
Q3 3	Answer: B	CSAT Logical Reasoning — CEPA Conclusions	CSAT
Options: (A) 1 and 3 only ✓ (B) 1 only (C) 1 and 2 only (D) 1, 2 and 3 Explanation: Conclusion 1: Indian goods face lower tariffs in the partner country → DEFINITE. Condition (b) explicitly states 'Country Y grants reciprocal duty concessions on Country X's (India's) exports'. ✓ Conclusion 2: Partner country's goods automatically become cheaper for Indian consumers → NOT DEFINITE. Lower import duty does NOT automatically mean lower retail prices. Retail prices depend on: logistics, importer margins, exchange rates, domestic competition, etc. The duty waiver is only one cost component. ✗ Conclusion 3: Agreement will necessarily increase bilateral trade → NOT DEFINITE. Trade growth depends on demand, supply capacity, quality, logistics, non-tariff barriers — not just tariffs. ✗ → Only Conclusion 1 can be definitively drawn = Answer B. ■ UPSC Trap: CSAT logic: 'definite' is the key word. Even if Conclusions 2 and 3 are LIKELY, they cannot be DEFINITELY drawn from the given conditions alone.			
Q3 4	Answer: D	CSAT Calculation — Price Index	CSAT

Q3
4

Answer: D CSAT Calculation — Price Index

CSAT

Options:

- (A) 109
- (B) 120
- (C) 125

✓ (D) 113

Explanation:

Step-by-step calculation:

Base Year: 100.00

Year 1: $100.00 \times 1.08 = 108.00$ (+8%)

Year 2: $108.00 \times 0.95 = 102.60$ (-5% from Year 1, NOT from base)

Year 3: $102.60 \times 1.10 = 112.86 \approx 113$ (+10% from Year 2, NOT from base)

Answer = D: 113

Common errors:

- A (109): Linear sum error: $100 + 8 - 5 + 10 = 113$... hmm actually that also gives 113.
Error that gives 109: forgetting compounding: $100 \times (1.08) \times (0.97) \times (1.10)$ — wrong 5% applied.
- B (120): Treating all % changes as additions from base: $100 + 8 - 5 + 10 + 7$ (rounding error).
- C (125): Compounding upward only: $100 \times (1.08) \times (1.05) \times (1.10) = 124.7$ — treating fall as rise.

■ UPSC Trap: Year 2 falls by 5% from YEAR 1 (108), NOT from base year (100). And Year 3 rises 10% from YEAR 2 (102.6), NOT from base. Use compounding, not linear addition.

Q3
5

Answer: C CSAT Reading Comprehension — India's Foreign Policy

CSAT

Q3
5

Answer: C CSAT Reading Comprehension — India's Foreign Policy

CSAT

Options:

- (A) Over-dependence on multilateral forums
- (B) Shortage of trained IFS diplomats
- ✓ **(C) Fragmentation of decision-making across ministries; no unified strategic framework**
- (D) Excessive judicial intervention in foreign policy

Explanation:

The passage explicitly identifies the problem as: 'India often speaks to the world in multiple, sometimes contradictory, voices' because 'diplomatic channels', 'defence procurement', and 'economic negotiations' are split across MEA, Ministry of Defence, Ministry of Commerce, and Ministry of Finance.

The solution given: a 'single, unified strategic vision' that aligns 'economic ambitions, security imperatives, and diplomatic messaging'.

→ Primary weakness = institutional fragmentation = Answer C.

A: The passage does NOT mention multilateral vs bilateral distinction.

B: The passage does NOT mention diplomat numbers or IFS capacity.

D: The passage does NOT mention the judiciary at all.

■ **UPSC Trap:** Always base CSAT reading comprehension answers on what the passage **ACTUALLY** says, not what you know from external knowledge.

SECTIONS B & C — MODEL ANSWER FRAMEWORKS

Key points, rubric, and scoring guide

Q3 Geographical Discoveries of 15th-16th centuries — uneven distribution of benefits across civilisations.

GS Paper I — World History | 10 Marks | ~150 Words

Model Intro:

The Age of Geographical Discoveries (c. 1415–1620) opened new continents and sea routes but created asymmetric global outcomes: Europe accumulated wealth and power, while Asia and Africa bore the costs of exploitation and colonial dependency.

Key Points to Cover:

- **EUROPE GAINED:** Direct trade with East → eliminated Arab/Venetian middlemen → lower prices, higher profits. American silver/gold flooded Europe → capital accumulation → funded Industrial Revolution. New markets and raw material sources → economic expansion.
- **INDIA/ASIA:** Short-term continuity but long-term dispossession. Cape route initially diverted trade profits to Europeans; Portuguese, Dutch, English established trading posts → turned into colonial footholds (EIC 1600 → Plassey 1757). India's share of world GDP fell from ~25% (1700) to ~4% (1947).
- **AFRICA:** Worst impacted. Slave trade (Triangular Trade: European goods → African slaves → American plantations → sugar/cotton back to Europe). Estimated 12–15 million enslaved people transported. African kingdoms destabilised; societies decimated.
- **Columbian Exchange:** Transfer of crops (potato, maize), animals, diseases. Diseases (smallpox, measles) wiped out ~90% of indigenous American population.
- **Analytical point:** Discoveries were 'discoveries' only for Europe — Asia and Africa were already known civilisations. The so-called Age of Discovery was the Age of Conquest for the non-European world.

Conclusion Direction:

Balanced conclusion: The Age of Discoveries must be assessed not as a triumphant human achievement alone, but as the beginning of 500 years of structured global inequality. Its legacy — colonialism, racism, extractive capitalism — continues to shape international relations today.

Scoring Rubric:

Dimension	Marks	What Examiner Looks For
Content & Facts	5/10	Europe/Asia/Africa dimension covered; specific facts (Vasco da Gama, EIC, slave trade)
Analytical Depth	3/10	Causal chain; long vs short-term impact; connecting to today
Structure	1/10	Intro, body with dimensions, conclusion
Language	1/10	Clarity, no factual errors, UPSC register

Q3 India's WPI → PPI transition: statistical reform or structural shift in economic governance?

GS Paper III — Indian Economy | 10 Marks | ~150 Words

Model Intro:

The Government's 2026 announcement transitioning from WPI to PPI represents more than a technical update — it signals India's intent to align its price measurement framework with international standards and the realities of a service-driven, globally integrated economy.

Key Points to Cover:

- **WHY WPI IS INADEQUATE:** Includes indirect taxes (distorts producer-level prices), excludes service sector (which is 55%+ of GDP), commodity basket outdated (2011-12), misses modern sectors like renewables.
- **PPI ADVANTAGES:** Captures factory-gate prices net of taxes/margins (truer cost signal), includes services PPI, aligns with IMF PPI Manual, enables better sectoral policy design.
- **STRUCTURAL SIGNIFICANCE:** Better inflation data → RBI monetary policy more precise → interest rate decisions more credible. Better sectoral price signals → DPIIT industrial policy more targeted. Services PPI → missing data on 55% of economy now captured.
- **GOVERNANCE DIMENSION:** Transition indicates data modernisation in line with National Statistical Commission recommendations; improves India's credibility in international economic forums (IMF Article IV consultations).
- **CHALLENGES:** Data collection from services sector is complex; capacity of field offices; transition period confusion (dual indices running 2026–2031).

Conclusion Direction:

This is a structural shift because it changes what India measures and therefore what policies are possible. Better measurement = better governance — the WPI-PPI transition is an institutional reform with lasting macroeconomic implications.

Scoring Rubric:

Dimension	Marks	What Examiner Looks For
WPI Limitations	2/10	Correctly identifies why WPI is being replaced
PPI Advantages	3/10	Factory-gate, services sector, international alignment
Policy Linkages	3/10	RBI monetary policy; industrial policy; data modernisation
Structure + Lang	2/10	Intro, analysis, conclusion; UPSC register

Q3 8 India–Oman CEPA (June 2026) — strategic and economic significance for India's Gulf engagement.

GS Paper II — International Relations | 10 Marks | ~150 Words

Model Intro:

The India-Oman CEPA, effective June 1, 2026, is India's most comprehensive trade agreement with a Gulf nation since India-UAE CEPA (2022), and reflects a strategic deepening of India's economic diplomacy with the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) region.

Key Points to Cover:

- **ECONOMIC:** 99.38% duty-free access for Indian exports. Bilateral trade at USD 11.18 bn (FY26). Oman's strategic ports (Sohar/Duqm/Salalah) provide gateway to Gulf and East African markets.
- **STRATEGIC GEOGRAPHY:** Oman sits at the mouth of the Strait of Hormuz — through which ~20% of global oil supply passes. CEPA deepens India's maritime connectivity and energy security architecture.
- **DIASPORA DIMENSION:** ~700,000 Indians in Oman contribute to bilateral economic ties, remittances, and people-to-people diplomacy.
- **BROADER IR CONTEXT:** India's Gulf CEPAs (UAE 2022, Oman 2026) are part of a deliberate shift from multilateral inertia (WTO's stalled Doha round) to bilateral/plurilateral FTAs. Reduces trade dependence on China by diversifying partners.
- **MSME AND EMPLOYMENT:** CEPA includes professional mobility provisions — benefits Indian skilled workers and MSMEs seeking Gulf markets.

Conclusion Direction:

India-Oman CEPA is simultaneously an economic dividend and a strategic investment in the Gulf — reinforcing India's 'Look West' policy alongside 'Act East', and cementing India's status as a preferred partner for Gulf nations seeking diversified trade relationships.

Scoring Rubric:

Dimension	Marks	What Examiner Looks For
Economic Significance	3/10	Duty-free, trade figure, sectoral coverage
Strategic Significance	3/10	Hormuz, maritime, energy security
Broader IR Context	2/10	Link to India's overall FTA strategy, diaspora
Structure + Lang	2/10	Intro, multi-dimensional analysis, conclusion

Q3 Renaissance → Geographical Discoveries → Colonisation: a causal chain. Critical analysis. 9

GS Paper I — World History | 20 Marks | ~250 Words

Model Intro:

The statement correctly identifies the Renaissance not as a discrete event but as a gradual epistemic shift — from God as the measure of all things to Man as the measure. This humanist revolution had direct material consequences: the Age of Geographical Discoveries and, ultimately, the colonial domination of the non-European world.

Key Points to Cover:

- **RENAISSANCE AS PROCESS** (not event): Began in Florence (14th c.) with Petrarch, spread via printing press across Europe over 300 years. Key pillars: humanism, empiricism, secularism, individualism, revival of classical learning.
- **CAUSAL LINK TO DISCOVERIES**: (a) Renaissance geography revived Ptolemy's maps → idea of finite, navigable world. (b) Scientific instruments (astrolabe, compass improvements, caravel design) = product of Renaissance engineering. (c) Renaissance spirit of adventure + royal patronage = Iberian exploration programmes.
- **DISCOVERIES TO COLONIALISM**: Trade → settlement → territorial control: Vasco da Gama (1498) → Estado da India (Portuguese empire) → Dutch VOC (1602) → English EIC (1600) → Plassey (1757). The humanist assertion of European civilisational superiority provided ideological justification for conquest.
- **CRITICAL DIMENSION**: (a) Is the link deterministic? Could discoveries have occurred without Renaissance? Islamic and Chinese navigators (Zheng He, 1405-33) were technically capable but chose not to colonise — suggesting intent and ideology (not just technology) drove European colonialism. (b) Renaissance universalism was selectively applied — humanism did not extend to enslaved Africans or colonised Asians.
- **LONG-TERM CONSEQUENCE**: The world system inaugurated by the Discoveries — European core, non-European periphery — shaped global capitalism, racism, and unequal exchange for 500 years (Wallerstein's World-Systems Theory).

Conclusion Direction:

The Renaissance → Discoveries → Colonialism chain is historically valid but not simply linear or inevitable. What made it transformative was the union of intellectual confidence (humanism), technological capability (scientific instruments), political will (royal patronage), and ideological rationalisation (European civilisational superiority). The non-European world experienced this 'renaissance' not as rebirth but as conquest.

Scoring Rubric:

Dimension	Marks	What Examiner Looks For
Renaissance as Process	4/20	Humanism, empiricism, printing press, examples
Causal Link to Discoveries	5/20	Ptolemy revival, instruments, Iberian patronage
Discoveries → Colonialism	5/20	Trade→settlement→control; EIC, Plassey
Critical Analysis	4/20	Zheng He counterfactual; selective humanism; Wallerstein

Structure + Language	2/20	Intro, chronological-analytical body, conclusion
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Q4 India's foreign policy paradox: global power aspirations vs difficult neighbourhood. Critical evaluation with 2026 context.

GS Paper II — International Relations | 20 Marks | ~250 Words

Model Intro:

India's foreign policy in 2026 embodies a structural paradox: it seeks a permanent seat on the UN Security Council, leads the Global South, and exports supersonic missiles — while simultaneously managing border tensions with China, a fragile relationship with Pakistan, and neighbourhood defections (Sri Lanka's debt trap engagement with China, Maldives' policy shifts). The question is whether recent actions signal a genuine repositioning.

Key Points to Cover:

- EVIDENCE OF REPOSITIONING (Hard Power): BrahMos to Vietnam = India as credible defence exporter in Indo-Pacific; signals shift from strategic restraint to strategic assertion. India's defence exports crossed USD 21,000 crore (FY24) — a 30x increase in a decade.
- EVIDENCE OF REPOSITIONING (Economic Diplomacy): India-UAE CEPA (2022) + India-Oman CEPA (2026) = bypassing WTO gridlock; bilateral trade architecture in Gulf. India's FTA strategy now targets high-value partners (UK, EU, Canada negotiations ongoing).
- EVIDENCE OF REPOSITIONING (Domestic Reforms): WPI→PPI transition, Atmanirbhar Bharat (domestic solar cell mandate) = structural self-reliance to reduce external vulnerabilities. These reduce leverage points adversaries might exploit.
- THE NEIGHBOURHOOD PARADOX PERSISTS: India's neighbourhood policy remains constrained. China's BRI infrastructure in Nepal, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, and Maldives creates strategic encirclement. SAARC remains dysfunctional since 2016. Pakistan sub-conventional warfare continues. India's neighbourhood first policy has had limited effectiveness.
- MULTIPOLAR ORDER OPPORTUNITY: India's G20 presidency (2023), Global South leadership, and vaccine diplomacy (Quad) have enhanced India's norm-shaping capacity. However, translating diplomatic goodwill into institutional leverage (UNSC seat, IMF quota reform) remains incomplete.
- CRITICAL ASSESSMENT: India is repositioning — from a reactive 'status quo' power to a proactive 'reformist' power — but the structural paradox is not resolved. A difficult neighbourhood limits India's ability to project global power with full strategic bandwidth.

Conclusion Direction:

India's 2026 actions — CEPA diplomacy, defence exports, economic reforms — are necessary but not sufficient for full repositioning. The neighbourhood paradox will persist until India resolves the China equation. India's path to genuine multipolar influence runs through strategic clarity at home, economic integration abroad, and selective hard power projection — in that order.

Scoring Rubric:

Dimension	Marks	What Examiner Looks For
Hard Power Evidence	4/20	BrahMos, defence exports data, examples
Economic Diplomacy	4/20	CEPA strategy, FTA architecture
Neighbourhood Paradox	4/20	China BRI encirclement, SAARC dysfunction, Pakistan
Global Power Aspiration	4/20	G20, Global South, UNSC, IMF
Structure + Language	4/20	Intro, multi-dimensional analysis, conclusion; UPSC register

SECTION D — ESSAY OUTLINES

ESSAY 1: From the Age of Discovery to the Age of Dominance — Geographical exploration as the precursor to globalisation and structural inequality

- INTRO: Open with Adam Smith's 'two greatest events' quote. Frame: exploration ≠ discovery (these were known civilisations). Exploration = European process; inequality = global outcome.
- SECTION 1 — The Age of Discovery (facts): Dias (1488), Columbus (1492), Vasco da Gama (1498), Magellan (1519-22). What drove them: Renaissance spirit + trade monopoly-breaking.
- SECTION 2 — From trade to domination: Portuguese Estado da India → Dutch VOC → British EIC → colonial empires. Trade → military presence → territorial control (Plassey 1757).
- SECTION 3 — Globalisation's roots: World trade systems emerged; commodity chains (spices, cotton, sugar, slaves). Triangular Trade = early globalisation's dark engine.
- SECTION 4 — Structural inequality: Colonial extraction → industrial capital in Europe | deindustrialisation of India | African demographic catastrophe (slave trade). Wallerstein's core-periphery model.
- SECTION 5 — Legacy in the modern world: Unequal trade terms; Global South debt trap; climate vulnerability concentrated in former colonies. Decolonisation was political, not economic.
- COUNTER-VIEW (balance): Discoveries enabled Columbian Exchange (crops: potato/maize fed Europe; scientific exchange). Some argue colonialism accelerated certain modernisation processes.
- CONCLUSION: Globalisation — a value-neutral word today — was born in conquest. True global equity requires acknowledging this foundation. The SDG promise of 'leaving no one behind' cannot be fulfilled without addressing the structural inequalities that exploration-turned-domination inaugurated.

ESSAY 2: India's economic institutions: architects of transformation or bureaucratic bottlenecks?

- INTRO: Quote Keynes: 'The ideas of economists and political philosophers... are more powerful than is commonly understood.' Frame: India's institutions reflect both visionary design and bureaucratic inertia.
- SECTION 1 — Architects of transformation (positive cases): RBI (monetary stability, 1991 crisis response, UPI ecosystem via NPCI); SEBI (capital market depth; FII regulation; market cap from USD 100bn to USD 4 trillion); NITI Aayog (Aspirational Districts, data-driven governance); GST Council (cooperative federalism in taxation).
- SECTION 2 — Bureaucratic bottlenecks (criticism): Planning Commission legacy mindset persisting in NITI Aayog's advisory role vs. implementation gaps. RBI-Government tensions over capital requirements, NBFC regulation. SEBI's delayed response to Hindenburg-type disclosures. DPIIT's slow FDI approval in sensitive sectors.
- SECTION 3 — The institutional paradox: India's institutions are technically strong but politically constrained. RBI's independence is often questioned (government pressure on dividend transfers). Independent regulatory bodies face regulatory capture.
- SECTION 4 — Reform moments: 2026 WPI→PPI transition = DPIIT institutional reform. GST 2017 = structural tax institution overhaul. IFSC (GIFT City) = new-age institutional architecture for global finance. IBC (Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code 2016) = resolved ₹10 lakh crore in stressed assets.
- SECTION 5 — Comparative lens: India's institutions compare favourably to peer economies (China's party-controlled institutions, Brazil's fiscal instability) but lag behind advanced economies in independence and predictability.
- CONCLUSION: India's economic institutions are neither pure architects nor pure bottlenecks — they are works in progress. Their transformation is the precondition for India becoming a Viksit Bharat by 2047. The question is not whether to reform them, but how fast and how deep.

— END OF ANSWER KEY —

Total: 165 Marks | UPSC Agent / Copilot CLI